22,752, which is a pointer to hoarding of cash, indicating that people are feeling uncertain and vulnerable. Experts, however, say that the reforms in telecom announced last year promise to revive the sector, and the production-linked incentive schemes for manufacturing are game-changers.

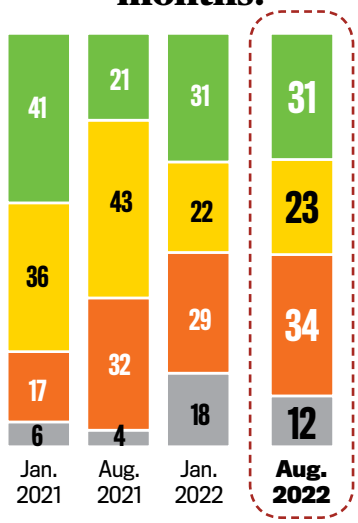
INFLATION, JOB LOSS HEAT

In terms of the outlook for the Indian economy in the next six months, 34.2 per cent of respondents said it will get worse and 30.5 per cent said it will improve. This pessimism is higher than it was in the first year of the pandemic. On household incomes and salaries, 27.6 per cent expressed optimism that they will improve, a substantial uptick from 17 per cent in August last year. Inflation for June eased a bit to 7.01 per cent following the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) aggressive interest rate hikes, but it remains much above the central bank's target inflation upper limit of 6 per cent. Inflation pinches the pockets of the man on the street as prices of fuel, grains, pulses and vegetable oils rise. Higher fuel prices have a cascading effect across the supply chain, making the production and transportation of goods more costly. Inflation has eaten into household budgets—63 per cent said current expenses are difficult to manage, down from 67.3 per cent in January, and 26.9 per cent said expenses have risen though still manageable.

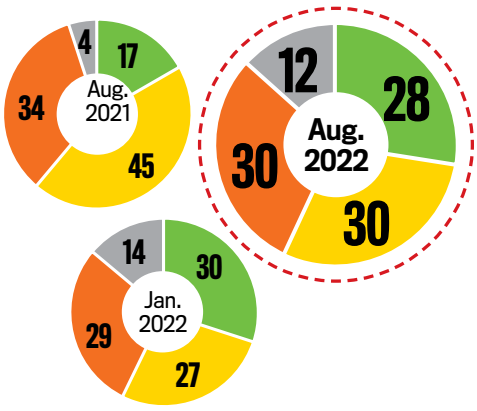
60
PER CENT
IN THE NORTH AND NORTHEAST—TWO BIGGEST SUPPORT REGIONS FOR MODI AND THE BJP—SEE UNEMPLOYMENT AS A VERY SERIOUS ISSUE

With Covid striking the country in early 2020, the impact on jobs has been disastrous. According to the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE), nearly 78 million jobs were lost dur-

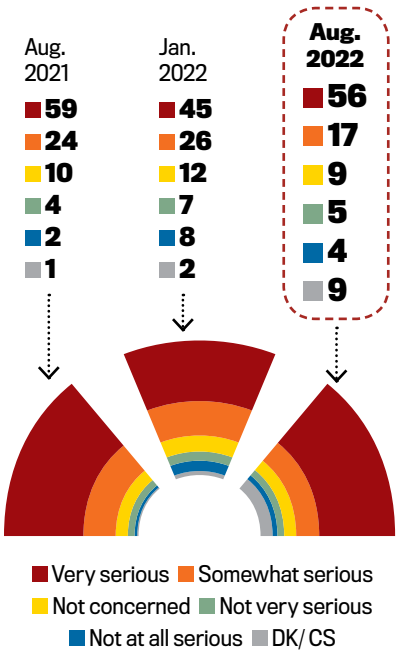
Q. How do you see the Indian economy in the next six months?



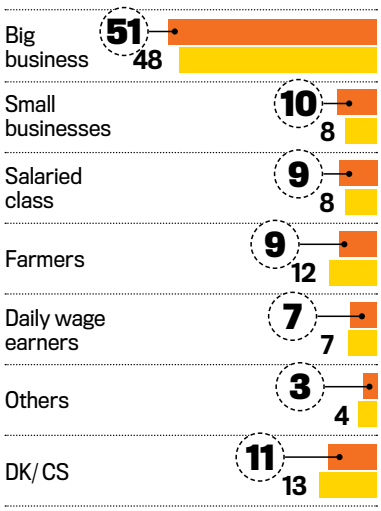
Q. Is your household income/ salary likely to improve?



Q. How do you view the unemployment situation in the country?



Q. Who do you think has benefitted the most from the NDA government's economic policies?



DK/ CS: Don't know/ can't say

(All figures in percentage)

Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY